PEOPLE MANAGEMENT SKILLS FOR MANAGERS

BMS – Organisational Behaviour

A real-business situation for reflection and classroom discussion

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand why people management is central to managerial effectiveness

Identify key people-management skills required by managers

Analyse how managerial behaviour affects employee and business outcomes

Distinguish task management from people management

Reflect on how managers can improve employee performance through relationships

WHAT ARE PEOPLE MANAGEMENT SKILLS?

People management skills are the abilities managers use to understand, communicate with, motivate, support, develop and influence employees toward organisational goals.

They include communication, active listening, emotional intelligence, empathy, coaching, feedback, conflict management, motivation, delegation and recognition.

Effective people management connects employee capability and commitment with organisational performance.

REAL BUSINESS SITUATION: STARBUCKS STORE

A busy Starbucks store is experiencing increasing customer complaints.

Employees face long queues, staff shortages and pressure to serve customers quickly.

The store manager, Alex, is strongly focused on sales targets and operational efficiency.

When employees make mistakes, Alex publicly criticises them and tells them to work faster.

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT?

Initially, productivity appears to improve.

Over time, employees become reluctant to communicate with Alex.

Experienced employees begin considering other jobs.

New employees receive limited support from experienced staff.

Team members begin blaming one another for mistakes.

Customer complaints increase further.

Absenteeism and disengagement increase.

THE MANAGER'S QUESTION

Alex is confused: "I have clearly communicated the targets and given employees instructions. Why isn't the team performing?"

BMS reflection question:

Is this primarily a productivity problem—or a people management problem?

What is the manager failing to understand?

EXPERIENTIAL ACTIVITY: YOU ARE THE STORE MANAGER

Form four groups.

Group 1 – Task-Focused Manager: improve performance through targets and monitoring.

Group 2 – People-Focused Manager: improve performance through communication, motivation and support.

Group 3 – HR Manager: design people-management interventions.

Group 4 – Employee Perspective: identify what employees need from their manager.

Preparation: 10 minutes | Presentation: 3 minutes per group

THE HIDDEN PEOPLE PROBLEM

Public criticism can reduce trust and psychological safety.

Pressure without support can reduce motivation and engagement.

Poor communication can prevent managers from learning about operational problems.

Blame can weaken teamwork and cooperation.

Experienced employee turnover can reduce organisational knowledge.

The manager may be managing tasks while neglecting people.

KEY PEOPLE MANAGEMENT SKILLS

Communication – communicate expectations clearly and create two-way dialogue

Active listening – understand employee concerns before responding

Emotional intelligence – recognise and manage one's own and others' emotions

Empathy – understand situations from employees' perspectives

Constructive feedback – correct behaviour without humiliating the employee

Coaching – help employees learn and improve

Conflict management – resolve disagreements constructively

Motivation and recognition – encourage effort, contribution and achievement

PEOPLE MANAGEMENT SKILL → BUSINESS OUTCOME

Communication → Better coordination and fewer misunderstandings

Listening → Earlier identification of operational problems

Empathy → Stronger employee relationships

Feedback → Improved performance and learning

Coaching → Greater employee capability

Conflict management → Better teamwork

Recognition → Higher motivation and engagement

Delegation → Greater ownership and managerial capacity

TASK MANAGER VS PEOPLE MANAGER

Task-focused manager: “Did you complete the target?”

People-focused manager: “What is preventing you from achieving the target?”

Task-focused manager: “Work faster.”

People-focused manager: “What is causing the delay, and how can we solve it?”

Effective managers need both task orientation and people-management capability.

WHAT SHOULD ALEX DO?

Hold private, respectful performance conversations.

Ask employees about workload, staffing and process difficulties.

Use constructive feedback instead of public criticism.

Recognise employees who support customers and colleagues.

Coach new employees and encourage experienced employees to mentor them.

Address conflict and blame quickly.

Give employees appropriate autonomy and responsibility.

Monitor both business results and people indicators.

PEOPLE MANAGEMENT AND THE OB CONNECTION

Personality – understand individual differences

Perception – understand how employees interpret managerial actions

Attitudes – influence job satisfaction and commitment

Motivation – create conditions for effort and persistence

Emotions – manage workplace emotional responses

Groups – build cooperation and trust

Leadership – influence and develop employees

Culture – establish norms of respect, fairness and performance

GROUP DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

What is the root cause of the problem?

Which managerial behaviours are making the situation worse?

Which people-management skill is most important in this situation?

Can a manager be demanding without damaging employee relationships?

How should Alex balance employee needs and business targets?

What indicators would show that the intervention is working?

MANAGERIAL DASHBOARD: WHAT SHOULD ALEX MONITOR?

Business: sales, productivity, service quality and customer complaints

People: absenteeism, turnover, engagement and employee satisfaction

Team: conflict, cooperation, communication and peer support

Leadership: feedback quality, trust and employee voice

The objective is sustainable performance—not short-term target achievement alone.

KEY TAKEAWAY

A manager does not achieve results alone.

Managers achieve results through people.

Therefore:

Technical competence helps managers manage the work.

People management skills help managers enable people to do the work.

Sustainable organisational performance requires both.

BMS REFLECTION

Think of the best manager you have worked with.

What did that manager do that made you want to perform better?

Which people-management skills did you observe?

Did the manager focus more on tasks, people, or both?

What one people-management skill would you develop if you became a manager tomorrow?